

Spelling for the EPT

The rules behind English spelling, and the words most often misspelt

Study guide for the University of Ibadan Postgraduate Test of English (EPT)

The mechanics section includes spelling items in which only one of four similar forms is correct. Spelling becomes much easier once you know the handful of rules that explain most English words, and have learnt the common exceptions by heart.

The key rules

1 *i* before *e* , except after *c* (when the sound is "ee")

✓ believe, achieve, grief, field, niece

✓ receive, ceiling, deceive, conceit, receipt

Exceptions to learn: *seize, weird, either, neither, leisure, protein, foreign, height*.

2 Doubling the final consonant

Double the last consonant before a suffix beginning with a vowel (*-ed*, *-ing*, *-er*) when the word has one syllable, or the stress falls on the last syllable, and it ends in one vowel plus one consonant.

✓ run → running; stop → stopped; begin → beginning; occur → occurred, occurrence; prefer → preferred

✓ But: open → opened; visit → visited; benefit → benefited (*stress not on the last syllable*)

British English doubles a final *l* regardless of stress: *travel* → *travelled*, *cancel* → *cancelled*, *label* → *labelled*.

3 Dropping the silent *e*

✓ make → making; hope → hoping; argue → argument; true → truly

Keep the *e* to keep a soft *c* or *g* sound: *noticeable, manageable, courageous*. Keep it before a consonant suffix: *hopeful, statement* (but *argument, truly, ninth*).

4 *y* to *i*

✓ happy → happiness; carry → carried; beauty → beautiful

Keep the *y* before *-ing* and after a vowel: *carrying, played, enjoyment*.

5 Plurals

- ✓ -s: books; -es after s, x, z, ch, sh: boxes, churches
- ✓ -y after a consonant → -ies: cities; after a vowel → -s: days
- ✓ Some -f/-fe → -ves: knife → knives, half → halves (but chiefs, roofs, beliefs)
- ✓ Latin and Greek plurals in academic writing: criterion → criteria, phenomenon → phenomena, datum → data, thesis → theses, analysis → analyses, hypothesis → hypotheses

6 Prefixes do not change the root

- ✓ mis + spell = misspell; un + necessary = unnecessary; dis + satisfied = dissatisfied; im + mature = immature

7 -able or -ible?

If the root is a complete word, it is usually *-able*: *acceptable, dependable, comfortable*. If it is not, it is usually *-ible*: *visible, possible, edible, eligible*. Learn the exceptions: *responsible, sensible, flexible*.

8 -ance or -ence, -ant or -ent

There is no reliable rule, so learn the common ones: *maintenance, appearance, significance, relevant*; but *existence, independence, occurrence, persistent, correspondence*.

British and American spelling

The EPT follows **British** spelling.

British (use)	American
colour, honour, labour, behaviour	color, honor, labor, behavior
centre, metre, theatre	center, meter, theater
programme (but computer <i>program</i>)	program
travelled, cancelled, counsellor	traveled, canceled, counselor
defence, licence (noun), practice (noun) / practise (verb)	defense, license, practice
analyse, paralyse, catalogue	analyze, paralyze, catalog
haemoglobin, anaemia, oesophagus	hemoglobin, anemia, esophagus
storey (floor of a building), cheque, tyre, kerb	story, check, tire, curb

NOTE

Both *-ise* and *-ize* are accepted in British English (*organise* or *organize*), but be consistent. Some words take only *-ise*: *advertise*, *advise*, *compromise*, *exercise*, *supervise*, *surprise*.

Words most often misspelt

The letters that usually cause trouble are underlined.

accom <u>mo</u> dat <u>io</u> n	ach <u>ie</u> ve	ac <u>q</u> uire	ad <u>dr</u> ess
aggr <u>ess</u> ive	app <u>ar</u> ent	arg <u>u</u> ment	bel <u>ie</u> ve
bus <u>in</u> ess	cal <u>en</u> dar	co <u>mmi</u> ttee	co <u>ns</u> cientious
co <u>ns</u> cious	conven <u>i</u> ent	definit <u>e</u>	des <u>cri</u> be
des <u>per</u> ate	dys <u>ent</u> ery	embarr <u>ass</u>	environ <u>me</u> nt
exaggr <u>ate</u>	exist <u>en</u> ce	fore <u>ig</u> n	fulf <u>il</u>
gove <u>rn</u> ment	grate <u>fu</u> l	griev <u>ou</u> s	guar <u>an</u> tee
harass	height	humor <u>ou</u> s	im <u>me</u> diately
indep <u>en</u> dence	irresistible	knowl <u>ed</u> ge	liaison
libr <u>ar</u> y	mainten <u>an</u> ce	millenn <u>i</u> um	mischiev <u>ou</u> s
missp <u>ell</u>	necess <u>ar</u> y	notic <u>e</u> able	occ <u>as</u> ion
occ <u>ur</u> rence	permiss <u>i</u> on	persever <u>an</u> ce	possess <u>i</u> on
prev <u>al</u> ent	privileg <u>e</u>	pronunciat <u>i</u> on	publicl <u>y</u>
quer <u>y</u>	quest <u>i</u> onnaire	receiv <u>e</u>	recomm <u>en</u> d
referred	relev <u>an</u> t	restaur <u>an</u> t	rhythm
schedu <u>e</u>	separ <u>e</u> te	sieg <u>e</u>	strenu <u>ou</u> s
successf <u>ul</u>	suppr <u>ess</u>	thres <u>h</u> old	tomor <u>ro</u> w
truly	unnecess <u>ar</u> y	unt <u>il</u>	vacu <u>u</u> m
Wednes <u>d</u> ay	wheth <u>e</u> r	withh <u>o</u> ld	

EXAM TIP

When two options look almost the same, split the word into syllables and say each one clearly: *ac-com-mo-da-tion* (double *c*, double *m*), *ne-ces-sa-ry* (one *c*, double *s*).

How to learn spellings

1. **Look, say, cover, write, check.** Look at the word, say it, cover it, write it from memory, then check.
2. **Find the hard part.** Most words have one tricky spot; underline it, as in the list above.

3. **Use memory aids.** "Separate has *a rat* in it"; "a secretary keeps a *secret*"; "necessary: one collar (c), two sleeves (s)".
4. **Keep a personal list.** Write down every word you get wrong in practice and review it weekly.
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